

8, *Dream of the Red Chamber* is an Excellent Literary Work Reflecting the Panorama of the Restoration-Bureaucratic Society

The more I read our country's historical materials, the more intensely I feel two points.

The first point is that the evidence proving the Chinese Empire experienced an interruption of **feudalization** and pivoted toward a **restoration-bureaucratic system** is simply overwhelmingly abundant! Is there a single page in the history books that doesn't scream this fact? It is merely that no one previously viewed this process from the correct perspective; thus, even though the evidence was piled right before their eyes, they remained completely blind to it.

For example, a few days ago, I stumbled upon a video on Bilibili (*a Chinese internet platform*). The video mentioned a point I had long known but constantly overlooked: under the *Lü-ling* (Statutory) system of the Sui and Tang Dynasties, officials could acquire land—known as *Yongye fields* (永业田 / hereditary estates)—based solely on their rank within the bureaucracy. This land could be inherited by their descendants and was exempt from taxes and corvée labor.

Let us consider that starting from the Song Dynasty, land was no longer included in the institutional salaries of officials, and that the earlier **classical empires**, represented by the Han Dynasty, also lacked the feature of strictly pegging land grants to bureaucratic ranks.

This characteristic of the *Lü-ling* state perfectly reflects the immaturity of the bureaucratic system during the early stages of its restoration. The consciousness of **feudalization**—especially the recognition of the paramount importance of land—was still pervasive in the minds of intellectuals at that time. For a time, the autocratic monarch was simply incapable of ruling the country by relying on a bureaucratic group entirely unmoored from landed property (脱产).

(Note: Here, "unmoored from landed property" does not mean the officials did not originate from the **landlord class**; rather, it means they did not rely on managing family estates to acquire and consolidate their social status, unlike the **aristocratic great clans** that vanished by the late Tang Dynasty. For the landless bureaucrats of the Song and later eras, landed property was merely a financial guarantee to facilitate their entry into an official career).

Therefore, during the Sui and Tang dynasties, the **bureaucratic state** had to adopt a "boiling a frog in warm water" approach to slowly disintegrate the power of the **aristocratic great clans**, actively attracting and fostering small-to-medium landlords to join the bureaucratic system, ultimately achieving its robust restoration by the Song Dynasty.

The second point is that although the Chinese in the past did not understand scientific principles and scientific methods, this did not prevent the brilliant minds within our nation—those who cared deeply about the fate of the people—from realizing that this society had already embarked on an irreversible, wicked path!

Among them, the most renowned and typical example is *Dream of the Red Chamber* (《红楼梦》) authored by Cao Xueqin (曹雪芹) (*though he naturally only completed the majority of it*). One of the primary reasons this Chinese literary masterpiece has profoundly moved readers for so long lies in the author's exquisitely detailed and authentic depiction of characters, plots, and social landscapes—which was inextricably linked to Cao Xueqin's personal experiences.

If we observe the social life of the Ming and Qing empires, it is impossible to ignore an issue mentioned by countless researchers: **If a family of the landlord class failed to achieve official**

rank through the imperial examinations within three generations, its decline and subsequent loss of class status were completely unavoidable.

This is the grim social reality of the **bureaucratic state**! Even though the **landlord class**, as the ruling class, clearly occupied the dominant position in social production, if they did not parasitically attach themselves to the bureaucratic system, they were entirely unable to protect their wealth across generations.

Consequently, they inevitably funneled the entirety of the **social surplus** into elevating their own status within the bureaucratic system. **This caused the effective investment ratio for science, technology, culture, and art across the entire society to plummet to near zero.**

Cao Xueqin himself, during his youth, endured the tragedy of his family's utter ruination and fragmentation due to political factors. His understanding of China's "official-centric society" (官本位社会) was etched into his very bones. It was precisely this sober, agonizing realization that culminated in *Dream of the Red Chamber*.

From a microscopic level, *Dream of the Red Chamber* provides a panoramic, dead-angle-free exhibition of the primary characteristics of the bureaucratic society in **Late Imperial China**, illustrating exactly how this "official-centric" nature manifested in every single corner of social life.

For example, when we observe Jia Baoyu (贾宝玉)—the male protagonist of the novel—it is not difficult to discern the profound narrative subversion embedded in his characterization as someone "indifferent to official honors and career."

Contemporary readers generally view Jia Baoyu as a decadent playboy (纨绔子弟), but did he genuinely commit any exceptionally ruinous acts to squander his family's wealth? Compared to the colossal fortune possessed by the Jia clan, how could his level of "squandering" possibly deplete it all within his single generation?

In reality, anyone who genuinely understands Chinese society will clearly see Cao Xueqin's true intention: **In China, social wealth is highly concentrated within the bureaucratic group. For them, "squandering wealth" is fundamentally a non-issue; no matter how much they squander, it will never truly cause the family's ruination. The only truly fatal blow is losing power within the bureaucratic system!** This is the sheer absurdity of the society.

Therefore, although there has always been controversy in China regarding the authenticity and literary quality of the last 40 chapters in the widely circulated version (通行本), I personally hold the continuator in immensely high regard.

Because if you look at it purely from the perspective of literary prowess, he indeed falls far short of Cao Xueqin. However, judging from his grasp of Cao Xueqin's authorial intent and his profound understanding of Chinese society, the continuator was an exceptionally brilliant mind.

The last 40 chapters of the widely circulated version (*The 120-chapter *Cheng-Gao* edition) perfectly captured the spirit of the book. The earlier prophetic verses (判词) had already decreed the ending: "like birds flying into the forest, leaving behind a vast, clean emptiness" (飞鸟投林, 落了片白茫茫大地真干净). **But how exactly this "clean emptiness" would be achieved is the crucial factor determining whether this novel could become a monumental masterpiece.**

The four great families possessed noble titles, sprawling lands, massive industries, and infinite social connections; their accumulated wealth was astronomical. How do you write about their downfall? It is extremely simple: **"They no longer had anyone in the officialdom"** (官场上没人了).

Consequently, in Chapter 95 and Chapter 96, both Wang Ziteng (王子腾) and Jia Yuanchun (贾元春 / the Imperial Concubine) died. Conversely, Li Wan's son, Jia Lan (贾兰), passed the provincial examinations (考中举人), and their branch of the family instantly ascended to heaven like the proverbial *"even the chickens and dogs rising to the sky"* (鸡犬升天).

This simultaneous plummet and ascent thrusts the absolute concept of **"official-centricity"** (官本位) directly before the readers' eyes! Noble titles, gold and silver, landed estates, commercial routes, social connections—all of them are utterly useless.

Just as Emperor Zhenzong of Song wrote in his *Exhortation to Learning* (劝学诗): as long as you secure an official position, all these things will naturally come rolling in; yet without official positions, they will inevitably vanish without a trace!

It is precisely this internal social structure that sharply distinguishes the society of **Late Imperial China** from the contemporaneous societies of Western Europe and Japan. Jia Baoyu had no interest in an official career, viewing the so-called "righteous knowledge" (of the imperial exams) as utterly filthy. His viewpoint was completely correct!

His personal value orientation points directly to the root cause of the four great families' decline: their loss of power within the bureaucratic system. Simultaneously, it perfectly illustrates the absolute nature of the entire society's doctrine of **"All benefits must flow from a single source"** (利出一孔).

Meanwhile, the stories of the two female protagonists and dozens of supporting characters concentratedly reflect the monistic value orientation of the entire society and the suffocating oppression suffered by every social stratum under the bureaucratic system.

In this way, *Dream of the Red Chamber* uses the decline of the four great families as the main thread to showcase the motion of such a society: **The rise, fall, glory, or humiliation of any individual or any group depends entirely—and almost exclusively—on their power within the bureaucratic system.**

Throughout human history, there has never been a literary work that so penetratingly and incisively revealed the behavioral logic of a civilization occupying one-third of the global population and sprawling across 14 million square kilometers (*at the time including Korea and Vietnam*)!

It factually reflects the root causes behind the so-called **"Great Divergence"** (大分流 / *quotation marks indicate my personal reservations about this term*) operating globally on the eve of the modern era regarding its East Asian branch (*excluding Japan*): **Why, while a minority of nations and regions marched toward modernization, were others doomed to inevitably perish amidst a series of catastrophes.**

In the future, any scholar researching Chinese history will find it impossible to bypass this book.

However, the true greatness of *Dream of the Red Chamber*—its socio-historical significance—has not been fully recognized. This is deeply regrettable and immensely unfair to both Cao Xueqin and the continuator.

If one notes the global acclaim bestowed upon the Colombian literary giant Gabriel García Márquez and his works, this becomes easy to understand. If Márquez wrote the "**Magical Realism**" (魔幻现实主义) literature of Latin America, how is what Cao Xueqin wrote not the Magical Realism literature of East Asia?!

Judging by the scale of its impact, its duration, and its reflection of the essential difficulties encountered in the development of human society, the former cannot even remotely compare to the latter; the latter deserves vastly greater attention and acclaim.

But it is tragically helpless that within the political atmosphere of mainland China, it is practically impossible for *Dream of the Red Chamber* to receive a just evaluation.

And this is precisely what makes Cao Xueqin himself truly astonishing! This sociologist, disguised as a literary author, saw through the lamentable tragedy of the society he lived in and the compatriots around him more than two centuries ago.

"Pages full of absurd words, a handful of bitter tears! They all say the author is a fool, but who understands the true flavor within?" (满纸荒唐言，一把辛酸泪！都云作者痴，谁解其中味？)

It is entirely unsurprising that he knew he was playing the lute to cows (对牛弹琴). Even a deafening bell cannot awaken people who have already been completely domesticated. The greatest genius in the world looks exactly like this.

As for the author of the last 40 chapters of the circulated version, I believe he was outstanding. Whether his literary grace was good or bad is simply a matter of fate; after all, rhetoric and grammar rely heavily on innate talent. But the continuator genuinely grasped the absolute soul of the entire book, which is no small feat.

For Cao Xueqin himself, how would he have wanted the continuation of his work to be handled? Would he prefer a continuation with gorgeous prose that was entirely detached from the profound social reality the book reflected, or a continuation that—despite mediocre writing—tightly gripped its socio-historical essence?

I believe the answer is obvious. No matter how magnificent the prose, it is merely an external skin (皮囊). Cao Xueqin likely wrote this book out of profound indignation and grief; the soul of the book is obviously vastly more important than any beautiful skin!

8, 《红楼梦》是反映复辟官僚社会全景的极佳文学作品

我越是阅读我国的历史资料，就越强烈地感受到了两点，第一点是证明中华帝国经历了封建化中止并转向官僚制复辟的证据简直太多太多，历史书上哪一页写的不是，无非从前没有人以正确的视角看待这个过程于是尽管证据全部堆在眼前也看不到罢了。例如我前几天偶然在 bilibili（中国互联网平台）上刷到一个视频，视频中提到了我虽然早已知道但是一直忽视的一点，那就是在律令制下官员是可以凭在官僚体制中的地位获得土地的（永业田），这些土地会由子孙世袭并免课役。如果我们考虑自宋朝开始官员的制度性俸禄中就不再包括土地，而之前以汉代为代表的古典中华帝国也不具备将土地与官阶严格挂钩的特征。律令国家的这一特点恰恰反映了在官僚制度复辟之初还并不成熟的特点，封建化的意识特别是对土地重要性的认识在当时仍然普遍存在于知识分子的头脑中，专制君主一时间也无法凭借一个彻底脱产的官僚集团统治国家。（这里的脱产并不是指官员不出身于地主阶级，而是指其不像在唐朝末年消失的士族那样依赖经营家族土地取得并巩固社会地位，田产对宋及以后脱产官僚来说仅仅是自己进入仕途的经济保障）。因此官僚国家不得不在隋唐两代采取一种温水煮青蛙的方式瓦解士族的权势，吸引并扶植中小地主加入官僚体制中，最终在宋代实现了其稳固复辟。

第二点则是虽然在过去中国人并不了解科学原则以及科学方法，但是这并不能阻止我们民族中那些聪明并且关心人民命运的头脑去认识到这个社会已经走上了一条无法回头的邪路。其中尤为知名和典型的就是曹雪芹所著的《红楼梦》（当然他只完成了大部分），这本中国的文学名著之所以在长久以来能够打动读者的主要原因之一即在于作者对于人物，情节和社会风貌刻画得极为细腻真实，而这与曹雪芹本人的经历息息相关。如果我们观察明清帝国的社会生活，就不难不注意到一个无数研究者都提及的问题，那就是一个地主阶级家庭如果三代人内不能通过科举取得功名，其没落并失去阶级地位就是难以避免的。这是官僚国家的社会现实，哪怕地主阶级作为统治阶级明明在社会生产中占主导地位，但是如果不依附于官僚制度，就无法在代际之间保护自己的财富。因此他们必然将所有社会剩余都用来提升自己在官僚体制内的地位，使得整个社会对科学技术，文化艺术的有效投资比例几近为零。曹雪芹本人在少年之时经历了政治因素导致家破人亡的惨剧，他对于中国这个“官本位社会”的理解是刻骨铭心的，这种清醒的认识成就了《红楼梦》。《红楼梦》从微观层面，全景式的，无死角地展示了中华帝国晚期官僚社会的主要特征，“官本位”在社会生活中是如何体现的。

例如当我们观察贾宝玉小说中的男主角，就不难发现其被赋予的“不热心功名”的形象破局深意。当代人一般认为贾宝玉是一个纨绔子弟，但是他真的做过什么特别败家的事吗？比起贾家拥有的巨大财富，他书中的那个败家的程度，怎么可能在他那一代人败完？事实上，一个真正了解中国社会的人会非常清楚地看到曹雪芹的用意，中国的社会财富高度集中于官僚群体，对于他们而言，败家根本不是问题，再怎么败家也不会真的令家族败亡，反倒是在官僚体制中失势才是真正致命的，这就是荒唐之处。因此虽然国内一直对于通行本（程高本）后 40 回的真伪性和写作水准存在争议，但我本人对续作者是极为认可的。因为你要仅仅从文学素养的角度来看，他的确远远不能跟曹雪芹相比。但是如果从对曹雪芹的写作意图以及对中国社会的了解而言，续作者本人也是一个极为聪明的人物。通行本的后 40 回完全捕捉到了这本书的精神，之前判词已经讲了结局是飞鸟投林干干净净，但是怎么个“干干净净”法就是决定这本小说能不能成为伟大名著的关键。四大家族有爵位，有土地，有产业，有人脉，积累的财富极为庞大，怎么把他们写倒呢？很简单，“官场上没人了”。因此在 95、96 回中，王子腾和贾元春都死了。反倒是李纨的儿子贾兰考中了举人，一下子鸡犬升天。这一升一降，就把“官本位”这个概念呈现到读者的眼前。爵位、金银、土地、商路、人脉什么都没用了，诚如宋真宗的劝学诗所说，有了官位这些自然滚滚而来，然而没有这些官位它们也必然无影无踪。正是这样一种社会的内在结构，将晚期中国社会与同时期的西欧和日本社会截然地相区分。贾宝玉无心仕途，认为那些“正道”知识是肮脏的，他的看法一点没错。他本人的价值倾向就直指四大家族衰落的根本原因，也就是其在官僚体制内的失势，同时展现了整个社会绝对意义上的利出一孔。而两位女主角和其余数十个配角的故事则集中体现了整个社会价值取向的一元化以及官僚制度下社会各个阶层所受到的压迫。这样《红楼梦》就以四大家族的衰落为主线，展现了这样一种社会的运动：任何人，任何团体的兴衰荣辱都取决于且几乎仅取决于它在官僚体制内的权力。

人类历史上从来没有哪一部文学作品，能够如此这般一针见血地展现了一个占据了全世界 1/3 人口，幅员一千四百万平方公里的文明（当时还包括朝鲜、越南）的行为逻辑。它事实反映了近代前夜整个世界范围内的“大分流”（引号表明我本人并不完全赞同这一说法）在东亚这一支（除去日本）产生的原因，在少部分国家和地区走向现代化的同时，为什么另一些注定在一系列灾难中趋于毁灭。日后任何研究中国历史的学者都很难绕过这本书。然而《红楼梦》真正的伟大之处即其社会历史性没有得到充分的认识，这是非常令人遗憾的事情，对于曹雪芹和续作者两人也很不公平。如果人们注意到哥伦比亚文学家加西亚马尔克斯及其作品所受到的赞誉就不难理解这一点，如果说马尔克斯写的是拉丁美洲的魔幻现实主义文学，那么曹雪芹写的何尝不是东亚的魔幻现实主义文学呢？就其影响大小和持续时间及对人类社会发展中遇到的本质困难的反映来看，后者是前者远远不能相比的，后者理应受到更大的重视和赞誉。但是无可奈何的是，《红楼梦》在中国大陆的政治氛围中，几乎不可能获得公正评价的机会，而曹雪芹本人真正令人惊叹的地方也就在这里。这位伪装成文学家的社会学家，在两个多世纪前就早早看出了自己生活的社会还有自己同胞的可悲可叹，“满纸荒唐言，一把辛酸泪！都云作者痴，谁解其中味？”，完全不奇怪自己将要到牛弹琴，洪钟大吕震不醒已经被驯化的人，世间天才莫过于此。至于通行本后 40 回的作者我认为他是很出色的，文采上好不好那是没有办法的事情，毕竟修辞和文法也有赖于人的天赋，但续作者确实抓住了整部书的灵魂，这是很不容易的。对曹雪芹本人而言他会如何安排自己作品的续写？他会更认同一个文章华丽但是完全脱离了全书所反映的深刻社会现实的续写，还是一个虽然文笔一般却

紧扣社会历史性的续写？我认为回答是明显的，文辞再华丽不过也是皮囊罢了，曹雪芹写此书恐怕也有发愤而作之意，书的灵魂显然要比任何好看的皮囊更重要。